Original Article

Brand management to protect brand equity: A conceptual model

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ABSTRACT **Corporate and product brands are increasingly accepted as valuable intangible assets of organisations, evidence of which is apparent in the reported financial value that strong brands fetch when traded in the mergers and acquisitions markets. However, while much attention is paid to *conceptualising* brand equity, less is paid to how brands should be *managed* and delivered in order to create and safeguard brand equity. In this article we develop a conceptual model of corporate brand management for creating and safeguarding brand equity. We argue that while legal protection of the brand is important, by itself it is insufficient to protect brand equity in the long term. We suggest that brand management ought to play an important role in safeguarding brand equity and propose a three-stage conceptual model for building and sustaining brand equity comprising: (1) adopting a brand-orientation mindset, (2) developing internal branding capabilities, and (3) consistent delivery of the brand. We put forward propositions, which, taken together, form a theory of brand management for building and safeguarding brand equity. We illustrate the theory using 14 cases of award-winning service companies. Their use serves as a demonstration of how our model applies to brand management practice.**

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INTRODUCTION

The rising complexity of the business environment caused by changing markets, fragmentation of distribution and media channels, and the increasing importance of networks and emphasis on co-creation of value between the organisation and its customers, places greater emphasis on the value and management of intangible resources. Intangible resources play an increasing role in differentiating organisations and creating competitive advantage and include organisational capabilities, competences, skills and knowledge as well as brands.

There is growing realisation that brands, corporate and product are important intangible assets of organisations. Evidence of the importance of brands is apparent in the reported financial value of major brands and in the amounts that strong brands fetch when traded in the mergers and acquisitions markets. For example, the brand equity, in financial terms, of strong global brands represents a significant percentage of market capitalisation. In 1999, the brand value of the number one ranked brand Coca-Cola was 59 per cent of its market capitalisation; for number eight McDonald's, this was 64 per cent; and 77 per cent for number 22 ranked BMW.[1] However, although practitioners and academics give much attention to *conceptualising* brand equity, less attention has been paid to how the brand should be *managed* and delivered in order to create and safeguard brand equity.

The aim of this article is to develop a conceptual model of brand management for creating and safeguarding brand equity. First, the growing importance of intangible assets to organisations is discussed. The discussion highlights that, although brand is one of the organisation's major intangible assets, it is often excluded in some of the literature discussing the management of intangible assets. Second, different conceptualisations of brand equity are reviewed, followed by a discussion of the means of protecting brand equity, through both legal and brand management processes. In the discussion, we argue that legal protection of the brand alone is insufficient to protect brand equity and that brand management ought to play an important role in safeguarding brand equity. We then develop propositions, which taken together form a theory of brand management for building and protecting brand equity. The propositions comprising the theory are represented as a conceptual model. The theory is then illustrated using 14 cases of award-winning service companies, notwithstanding that the cases were not developed with our conceptual model in mind. Their use serves as an exploratory way of testing our model's practicality.

LITERATURE REVIEW

The growing importance of intangible resources to organisations

A steady shift is occurring from marketing management, which stresses exchange of tangible goods, customer focus, discrete transactions, value determined in the marketplace and marketing as a decision-making and problem-solving function, to a view of marketing as a social and economic process.[2] The emergent view attempts to unify literatures from fragmented domains, such as market orientation, including customer orientation,[3] services marketing,[4,5] relationship marketing,[6,7] quality management,[8] value and supply chain management,[9] resource management,[10] and network analysis.[11] The emphasis of the emergent view is on the exchange of intangibles, specialised skills and knowledge and processes and relationships for co-creating value with customers.

Although brands are valuable intangible assets that add value for business, they are missing from the emergent view of marketing.[2] Other researchers note this omission and argue for brand's inclusion.[12] In this article, we argue that brand is one of the most important intangible assets of the organisation, and therefore pay special attention to the safeguarding of its value or equity.

The brand equity intangible resource

Two perspectives of brand equity are prevalent, the cognitive customer-based[13] and a broader approach that combines the former with the financial equity of the brand.[14,15] North American scholars such as Aaker, Keller and Berry share the customer-based view of brand equity. Keller,[13] for example, views brand equity as the level of awareness and familiarity and the strength, favourability and uniqueness of brand associations that the consumer holds in memory. Brand equity exists when these cognitive elements are high. Aaker[16] conceptualises brand equity in terms of five asset components that are the sources of brand equity: brand loyalty, brand name awareness, perceived brand quality, brand associations (or brand image), perceived quality and other proprietary assets, such as patents, trademarks and channel relationships. For service brands, in which the company is often the brand, Berry[17] suggests that brand meaning, in addition to brand awareness, contributes to brand equity. Brand meaning refers to the customer's dominant perceptions of the brand. According to Berry, the presented brand, external brand communications and customer's experience with the company are the main sources of the consumer's perception of brand meaning.

Some European scholars and practitioners, on the other hand, adopt a broader perspective of brand equity to combine the customer-based perspective with the financial equity perspective of the brand. Of the latter view, Kapferer[14] and Feldwick[15] view brand equity in three distinct ways: (1) as the total value of the brand – when it is sold or on the company's balance sheet; (2) as a measure of the strength of the consumer's attachment to the brand and (3) as the description of the associations and beliefs that the consumer has about the brand. The first view represents the financial perspective of brand equity, while the second refers to brand equity as brand loyalty and the third to brand equity as brand image. The combined view of brand equity is process-based whereby brand assets (such as awareness, reputation, deep values and patents) produce brand strengths (such as market share, market leadership and brand loyalty as well as ability to fetch a price premium) that result in brand value in financial terms.[14] Kapferer[14] defines the brand's financial value as the 'net discounted cash flow attributable to the brand after paying the cost of capital invested to produce and run the business and the cost of marketing' (p. 14). However, the means of safeguarding brand equity needs further exploration.

Legal protection of brand equity

One form of protecting brand equity is through legal instruments such as patents and copyrights. Pharmaceutical companies, for example, protect their high research and development (R&D) investments through patents. Companies can also protect their logos as registered trademarks and literary publishing houses protect their publications via copyright laws. Although legal protection of brand equity is helpful, we contend that it is not sufficient for long-term brand equity protection.

The combined perspective of brand equity, outlined above, suggests that organisational competence in managing the brand could be the key to protecting brand equity in the long term. Kapferer[14] implicitly supports this assumption when he argues that market share, brand loyalty and financial value will result from correctly managing brand identity over time. In other words, in the long term, better management of the brand leads to better performance of the products and services represented by the brand. Although legal protection of brand might deter competitive infringement, it is the strategic management of the brand, which results in a brand personality with unique symbolic features and valued experience to the customer, making the brand more difficult for competitors to copy.[18] Strategic brand management, we argue, can safeguard brand equity and provide a long-term platform for sustainable competitive advantage to the organisation.

Brand management to build and protect equity

The thesis of this article is that safeguarding brand equity in the long term is conditional on the firm's competence in strategic brand management. In order to survive in the competitive environment, the brand needs to reflect the strategic vision of the firm. The literature review suggests that strategic brand management rests on having a brand orientation mindset and possessing internal branding and brand delivery capabilities. This suggests three stages of strategic brand management for building and protecting brand equity: (1) adopting a brand orientation mindset, (2) developing internal branding capabilities and (3) consistent delivery of the brand.

Brand orientation mindset

Brand orientation is 'an approach in which the processes of the organisation revolve around the creation, development, and protection of brand identity in an ongoing interaction with target customers, with the aim of achieving lasting competitive advantages in the form of brands' (p.117).[19] It is a mindset that entails that management goes beyond the marketing orientation with its focus on customer satisfaction and competitors, to a more deliberate and active development of brands that are imbued with emotional and symbolic values. According to Urde, brand orientation is 'market orientation plus' because it is also strategic in nature.[17] Brand orientation is therefore both *inside-out* (strategic) and *outside-in* (market) orientated.

Within the brand orientation mindset, brands are regarded as strategic resources and expressions of organisational identity, which can be linked to the organisation's competencies and the development of sustainable competitive advantage. The identity acquired through its brands represents the organisation's overall goals, values and positions. Urde[19] argues that brand management is a strategic mindset that challenges the market orientation assumption that the customer is always right. Brand building is seen as facilitating an interaction via symbols between the organisation and its customers. This entails creating a brand personality that provides meaningful and valued experiences to its customers and other stakeholders.

Research by Wong and Merrilees[20] concurs with the normative view of brand orientation proposed by Urde. Using a sample of senior executives from 400 firms, Wong and Merrilees empirically investigated whether brand orientation can partly close the marketing strategy–performance gap.[20] They found that brand orientation moderates the path from marketing strategy to brand performance. Companies with a high brand orientation, according to the findings, are able to get more out of their marketing strategy than those with a low brand orientation. These companies achieve a higher degree of focus on strategy development and implementation. Marketing mix variables receive greater attention, and consistency of strategy execution across the firm is greater in brand-oriented firms. This suggests that brand orientation not only focuses on the firm strategy but also acts as an interface between strategy and its implementation. Consequently, we argue that the path to creating and safeguarding brand equity begins with the adoption of a brand orientation mindset.

Internal branding and brand-oriented corporate culture

Instead of simply seeing the brand from an outside-in perspective, an inside-out perspective is also essential.[21] The argument is that it is no longer sufficient to simply position and communicate the brand externally. The need to embed the 'brand spirit' throughout the organisation is widely recognised in order to have organisation-wide support towards the brand strategy and implementation.[22] Brand spirit ensures that management and employees are part of brand reality and play an important part in conveying the brand meaning when interacting with customers and other stakeholders. A close link exists between the corporate brand and corporate culture, which is more critical in service organisations in which the company is also the brand. The relationship of culture to branding is succinctly expressed by de Chernatony[23] (p. 159):

> The new branding paradigm is therefore one which emphasises value through employees' involvement in relationship building. Internally brand management is becoming culture management and externally it is customer interface management. In the new branding mode corporate branding internally signals messages about the desired culture and externally it reduces information overload problems from line branding, decreasing customers' information processing costs.

Organisational culture and customer interface management are therefore key elements of internal branding. According to de Chernatony, creating internal brand reality starts with the inclusion of the human resource management director in the brand management team. Gulati[23] concurs with the strategic human resource perspective of internal branding. Gulati implies that changing the organisational structure, incentives and relationships, so that they are congruent with the strategy, facilitates culture and customer interface management, enabling the brand to deliver its customer-focused promise.

On the basis of a study of three firms, Gulati[23] identifies four sets of internal branding activities that successful companies engage in. These are coordination, cooperation, capability and connection. Coordination refers to establishing structural mechanisms and processes that allow employees to improve their focus on the customer. Cooperation refers to encouraging organisational people, through cultural means, incentives and the allocation of power, to work together for the customer. Capability development means ensuring that the organisation's people have the skills to deliver customer-focused solutions. Capability also means clearly defining career paths for employees with the requisite skills to deliver the brand. Connection entails developing relationships with external partners to deliver value to customers in a cost-effective way.

Ulrich and Smallwood[24] extend the notion of internal branding to include the leadership qualities of management required to build a leadership brand. They argue that a leadership brand is one with a reputation for developing exceptional managers with a unique set of skills geared to fulfil the customers' and investors' expectations. Such a brand inspires faith that employees and managers will consistently deliver the firm's promise. Concurring with the culture management perspective outlined above, Ulrich and Smallwood argue that a leadership brand is embedded in the organisation's culture, through policies and requirements placed on employees.[24]

In summary, based on the above discussion, internal branding necessitates recruiting and hiring the right management team and employees, and ensuring that management team members have the leadership qualities to build a leadership brand. A further requirement is training employees so that they have the requisite skills to deliver the brand. In addition, internal branding includes motivating employees, through career planning and incentives so that they live the brand, and developing relationships with external partners to deliver the brand in an economic way. At the heart of internal branding is a supportive organisational culture, which fosters a harmonious organisational climate.

Consistent brand delivery

Besides a brand orientation mindset and internal branding, the literature suggests that it is equally critical to deliver the brand consistently. Consistent brand delivery enhances the brand's positive reputation with customers. Brand reputation is one of the brand's major intangible assets.[14] According to Kapferer,[14] brand managers are responsible for simultaneously building the business and brand value, with sales and brand reputation used as the two key performance indicators to index managers' salaries. Chaudhuri[25] concurs with the view of reputation as an important brand asset.

Chaudhuri investigates the relationship between consumer-level perceptions of brands (brand familiarity and uniqueness) and market-level data on brand advertising and brand equity outcomes (market share and ability to charge premium price). The research shows that, although advertising and marketing are the main drivers of sales, their influence on two market outcomes of market share and ability to charge premium price is mediated by brand reputation. Advertising and the two market outcomes, market share and ability to charge premium prices, had no direct relationship. According to the Chaudhuri's model, brand familiarity and brand uniqueness determine brand reputation in the competitive market space. In other words, brand reputation stems from leveraging consumer-based consumer assets, which in turn determines brand strength, as discussed earlier.[14,15] Consistent delivery of the brand could aid brand familiarity and perceptions of brand uniqueness, thus enhancing brand reputation.

A growing body of literature associates brand reputation with constructs such as credibility and trust.[26,27] Delgado and Munuera-Aleman[27] view a brand as comprising a set of expectations that the brand offers a certain type and level of value. 'Providing this value on a consistent basis is at the heart of building strong relationships with consumers because they develop a sense of trust that the brand will continue to deliver that value' according to Delgado and Munuera-Aleman[27] (p. 193). Trust comprises two components, brand intentions and brand reliability. Brand reliability refers to the ability and willingness of the brand to deliver on the value promised.[26] Brand reliability equates to consistent delivery of the brand values. As such, consistent brand delivery is a determinant of trust, which in turn influences reputation and brand equity.

Erdem and Swait[26] suggest that a brand can signal credibility by possessing the expertise to deliver the brand values and being trustworthy. They define trustworthiness as the consumers' perceptions of the firm's willingness to carry through on promises made. This view reinforces the need to deliver the brand consistently at each touch point with stakeholders in order to achieve trustworthiness and a positive reputation. Thus, ensuring the consistent delivery of the brand should be a key part of a strategic brand management process for creating and safeguarding brand equity.

TOWARDS A BRAND MANAGEMENT THEORY TO BUILD AND PROTECT EQUITY

We have combined findings from the literature review to propose ideas for delivering the brand in order to safeguard brand equity. We have organised the ideas as propositions at this stage, which collectively form a theory of brand promise delivery.

P1 A brand orientation mindset is the first essential requirement towards safeguarding brand equity.

This proposition is based on the brand orientation literature. Adopting the brand orientation provides the entire business organisation with a strategic focus and a platform for creating customer and firm value. We argue that brand orientation focuses on strategy and culture development and because it is market-orientation plus, providing a bridge between strategy and execution.[18] Adopting a brand orientation mindset enables the partial closure of the gap between strategy and performance.[20] P1 therefore sets the stage for all the other propositions for safeguarding brand equity.

P2 Brand needs to be clearly defined before it can be developed into a strategic asset.

A clearly defined brand provides benefits to both the organisation and stakeholders. Within the organisation, it enables employees to understand the meaning behind the presented brand.[17] Clearly defining the brand is a step to brand strategy development because it makes explicit the rational and emotional benefits that customers and other stakeholders can expect from the brand.[14]

P3 Brand needs to be communicated so that its meaning is understood internally and externally.

Communicating the brand is an essential aspect of its implementation because it allows employees to know what the brand stands for, its values and aspirations. Doing so creates a greater chance of employee buy-in and commitment, which the literature suggests is essential to consistent brand delivery. Communicating the brand could benefit the customer because doing so could reduce customer's information processing costs.[21]

P4 Internal branding provides a key platform for living the brand within the organisation.

The literature review shows that building a leadership brand is contingent on internal branding. Internal branding facilitates the development of a brand-oriented corporate culture that results in senior management commitment and employee buy-in to live and deliver the brand. It enables management to examine the commitments that organisational people make to one another and to customers.[24] Another benefit of internal branding is that it allows reduction of the functional silos within the organisation that prevent inter-functional cooperation, which distract from focusing on delivering customer-focused solutions.[23] P4 ensures that management and employees live the brand.

P5a Corporate ability or expertise to deliver the brand promise contributes to the brand's credibility with stakeholders.

The literature shows that one way to achieve brand credibility is the ability or expertise to deliver the brand promise.[26] The brand's credibility contributes to its reputation with customers, which in turn contributes to brand equity.[27] P5a suggests that organisation ability to deliver the brand promise enhances brand reputation, which is essential to brand equity building.

P5b Brand equity is conditional on consistent and reliable delivery of the brand.

Brand reputation is an important brand asset. The literature review shows reputation is conditional among other things, on the presence of trust. A brand is considered trustworthy when customers perceive the firms' willingness to carry through on the promises made by the brand.[27] Trustworthiness exerts influence on consumers' brand consideration and choice.[26] P5a and P5b together emphasise the need to develop organisational expertise and gaining trust, both of which contribute to reputation, thereby enhancing brand equity.

P6 Brand recovery from perceived breaches of promise is essential to safeguarding reputation.

A trusted brand is often forgiven by customers when they perceive a breach of promise, and therefore the ability to recover from mishaps could be an essential part of managing the brand. Having a blue print of brand delivery[28] and planning for possible breaches of brand promise could guard against reputation erosion and contribute to brand equity protection. P6, therefore, is essential to the long-term protection of the brand's reputation, an essential component of brand equity.[14]

Three-stage model of brand management to build and protect brand equity

We combine the six propositions to form the basis for a composite theory of brand management to protect brand equity. We call the new theory 'the three-stage model of brand management to build and protect brand equity'. It is called a three-stage model because there are three distinct stages that together inform the brand management practice. The theory is concerned with both building and protecting brand equity. It assumes a strategic mindset for managing the brand. The three stages of the model are (1) adopting a brand orientation mindset, (2) internal branding and (3) consistent brand delivery.

Adopting brand orientation mindset

P1, P2 and P3 collectively form stage one of the conceptual model. P1, in particular, refers to the brand orientation mindset that we consider a key ingredient to managing the brand strategically. This mindset is more critical to corporate brands, but is equally relevant to product brands. It provides the platform for integrating activities throughout the organisation, which create sustainable competitive advantage for the brand. Treating the brand as a strategic resource allows management to create an identity that defines the brand's goals, values and competitive position.

P2 provides a clear focus to brand orientation because it calls for the need to clearly define the brand in terms of its purpose, vision, values, competencies and aspirations. This can be construed as brand strategy formulation. Until management can clearly define the brand, its chances of being understood by staff, customers and other stakeholders, we believe, are severely curtailed.

P3 refers to the need to communicate the brand because defining the brand without communicating it to staff, customers and other stakeholders, leaves it open to multiple interpretations at its various touch points. The perceived interpretations may not be congruent with the brand defined by management via P2.

Internal branding

P3, P4 and P5a collectively form stage two of our conceptual model. We consider communicating the brand internally (P3) an important step to brand strategy implementation. P4 refers to the need for internal organisation-wide brand buy-in. The organisation's people and other network partners are critical to delivering the brand. It is important that they internalise and live the brand. P4 focuses the organisation on this aspect to ensure that the right people are hired, trained, motivated and lead in a way that develops and sustains their commitment to the brand.

P5a is an important component of internal branding stage because it calls for the need to ensure that the organisation has the competence to deliver the brand. This refers to management and staff competence, as well as to availing resources, which bring the defined brand to life.

Consistent brand delivery

P5b and P6 collectively comprise the third stage of our conceptual model. P5b refers to the need for consistent and reliable delivery of the brand. Unless the brand is delivered consistently, its meaning could vary across its several touch points. Should the way the brand is delivered differ from its communicated meaning (its promise), this could affect its reputation and hence reduce its brand equity.

P6, which refers to the need to recover from breaches of the communicated brand, forms part of consistent brand delivery. When the organisation's people know that brand recovery is taken seriously within the organisation, they are more likely, we believe, to be motivated to rectify the breach. For customers, knowing that brand recovery is taken seriously by the organisation could allow them to forgive the breach. Customers could also be more likely to attribute the breach to other forces outside the brand's control.

ILLUSTRATING THEORY OF BRAND MANAGEMENT FOR CREATING AND SAFEGUARDING BRAND EQUITY USING 14 BEST PRACTICE CASE STUDIES

Existing cases are used to illustrate the propositions pertaining to the new theory of brand management to protect brand equity. The cases were taken from Berry[29] for several reasons. First, all of the cases relate to the service industry, facilitating a clear comparison of the firms with respect to branding. Second, the cases represent 14 award-winning cases in that sector. Third, branding was a key component of the investigation, although other components were also covered. Notwithstanding, the cases were not conducted with our proposed theory in mind, and therefore not all issues were tested for all aspects of the model. We now examine each proposition in turn.

P1: A brand orientation mindset is the first requirement towards safeguarding brand equity

All 14 cases seem to support the notion that, for a service company, the company is the primary brand rather than the product (service). There was general support that all the cases cultivated their brand – to communicate their 'reason for being' to customers and other stakeholders.

As an example, the *Container Store* cultivated its brand through steadfast adherence to its core strategy, a consistent message, creative advertising, community partnerships and living the brand through its employees.

Additional examples were less holistic in their support of the brand orientation concept, possibly because explicit articulation of the brand orientation was rare in 1999 when the cases were finished.

Complementary evidence from the cases indicated that each case had a strategic focus. Strategic focus is not necessarily a branding focus, but there is some overlap in emphasis.

P2: Clear definition of brand

The cases use strong forms of both colour (for example, green and white for *Enterprise Rent-A-Car*) and symbols (cows for *Chik-fil-A*). The *Dial-A-Mattress* name itself, as well as its advertising, projects a consistent message. Customers can buy Sealy, Serta or Simmons brand mattresses very simply (convenience) at good value.

Mid-west Express brand is famous for its 'best care in the air'. At the *Container Store*, the defining message remains constant – 'get organized, save time and space and simplify your life'.

P3: Communicate brand meaning internally and externally

Internal communications was common to communicate the brand internally. The *Container Store* used a variety of internal communication tactics.

However, two of the cases, *Enterprise Rent-A-Car* and *Midwest Express* specifically targeted employees as an audience for much of their external advertising. The external advertising not only sets the standard expected from the service, but also builds pride among the employees. The cleverness of this approach is that advertisements not only transfer information, but also help build internal commitment (pride). This means that targeting employees in external advertising supports both P3 and P4, to which we now turn.

P4: Platform for living the brand within the organisation

At *Chik-fil-A*, a key marketing approach has been to get the operators to take ownership of building the brand. The cows give the brand a distinct personality across markets and the operators strengthen the brand in their local markets. The local marketing effort is supported by head office marketing support.

New store openings at the *Container Store* are facilitated by collaboration with a local community charity. In addition to community partnerships and a consistent message (P2), the company builds its brand by living it through the service-mindedness of its employees. Reinforced through communications, the *Container Store* brand is the responsibility of all employees.

P5a: Corporate expertise to deliver the brand

The award-winning firms were serious about investing in employees in order to deliver the brand. Induction or orientation programmes were important. For example, *Midwest Express* conducts a two-day orientation programme for 25 to 30 new employees every week. The programme emphasises service delivery by simulating the experience of taking a flight. A 'boarding announcement' is made before the first session and lunch is served on a parked *Midwest Express* plane. Orientation of the company values is an important part of the induction programme.

At the *Container Store*, an entire week of induction is devoted to new employees, both full-time and part-time. The principles (values) of the company are an integral part of the induction programme.

Other case firms devote considerable resources to training and continuous learning. For example, *Charles Schwab*, *Miller SQA* and *Ukrop's Super Markets* operate their own corporate 'universities'. *Dana Commercial Credit* provides each employee with an average of 60 hours of in-house training and tuition-reimbursed education. The continuous learning reinforces the firms' core values. The various courses emphasise product knowledge and role playing. Coaching is also employed. The *Container Store* uses full-time coaches as well as less formal coaching methods. At *Dial-A-Mattress* some staff have one day of coaching a week included in their job function.

P5b: Consistent and reliable delivery of the brand

Although the role of external marketing communications helps, Berry[28] suggests that nothing is more important than the customers' actual experiences with the service. Being served freshly baked chocolate chip cookies as you relax in a comfortable leather seat on a *Midwest Express* jet defines brand meaning and builds brand equity more powerfully than any advertisement. Service with a smile also helps.

Enterprise Rent-A-Car connects emotionally with employees of local body shops, auto repair shops and insurance companies by taking donuts to them week after week, by building personal relationships and especially by keeping their explicit and implicit promises.

Chik-fil-A's cows invite customers' affection, but have to be backed up by customers' experiences with the service.

P6: Capability for brand recovery from perceived breeches

The emphasis in the cases studied seemed to be on reducing the probability of service errors and breakdowns in the first instance. Adherence to the previous propositions and a general pursuit of service excellence facilitate this goal. Thus, there was limited explicit discussion of service-recovery methods. The inference was, nonetheless, that there were adequate procedures for handling service failures.

Most of the case firms empowered the employee to solve problems if they occur. A number say it is ok to make mistakes (no blame), but focus instead on finding a better way or fix the process. This approach, of course, builds trust among the employees and helps to achieve greater buy-in to the brand.

DISCUSSION OF THE CASES

The 14 cases were not designed around a research protocol using the model, and therefore they are unable to do full justice to validating the model. Notwithstanding, each case did substantiate parts of the model. Collectively, all propositions were supported. Understandably, there were different nuances in how particular propositions were validated, reflecting the style of each organisation.

Overall, the theory is supported. Evidence backs the newly proposed model of brand management to protect brand equity. Previous research has been piecemeal, supporting part of the model. Now a more comprehensive approach is articulated and supported. The model helps integrate the entire brand management process, from a broad mindset and vision, through internal branding and finally consistent brand delivery.

CONCLUSIONS, LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

Although brand concepts and brand equity have been widely researched in the past two decades, less attention has been given to brand management and brand delivery to customers. The current article, with the help of evidence from 14 cases, redresses this gap by modelling the process from brand vision to internal branding to brand delivery.

The brand management process is elaborated using six propositions to conceptualise the three stages. All of the six propositions were supported, as was the three-stage model.

One limitation is that only best practice cases were used to illustrate the theory. Other cases are likely to fall short of the model. However, the model can be used by other firms to improve their protection of brand equity. Another limitation is that a theoretical paper can only propose a theory. Subsequent quantitative studies are needed to fully test the theory.

Future research could include quantitative studies to test the theory. It would also be interesting to examine the model in a non-service context such as manufacturing. Such studies could be either qualitative or quantitative.

IMPLICATIONS FOR BRAND EQUITY PROTECTION

The use of cases ensures that the model is practical, because of linkages to best practice service organisations. Successful service firms are using the model in part at least, and therefore it clearly has the potential to improve performance and brand equity and protect brand equity.

The three-stage model is easy to follow in practice and, in a sense, each proposition is a helpful checklist to any firm. Notwithstanding, it would seem that relatively few firms have fully embraced the model. Even within our 14 best practice firms, only a handful seemed to have made strong progress with all propositions (although this may be a limitation of the data). Thus, moving from a partial to a full adoption of all the propositions could be beneficial. Furthermore, there is scope to strengthen those situations in which a proposition is only weakly supported. For example, regarding Proposition 2, sometimes the brand definition is restricted to a brand slogan. Some of the award-winning service firms (or any firm) could benefit by imbuing greater meaning to the corporate brand and communicating that to all stakeholders.

In summary, the article progresses the idea that successful branding is not just about smart, creative brands, but also about well planned and executed brand management. Strong brands need to be well articulated, communicated and developed internally and delivered consistently. Intangible resources such as brands not only need to be recognised, but also safeguarded through well-designed brand management methods, and not simply by legal means.

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